

# The Strategic Thinking Handbook

A Full-Depth Reference for Strategic Analysis & Counterfactual Thinking

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2 sections • 32 frameworks • full-depth reference

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# Part I — Strategic Analysis Frameworks

*The structured methods executives reach for to analyze a situation before committing to a course of action — each optimized for a different kind of uncertainty, time horizon, or stakeholder configuration.*

## Force Field Analysis

### PURPOSE / CORE IDEA

Mapping the forces driving a change against the forces restraining it, to identify which to strengthen or weaken.

### ORIGIN & CREATOR

Kurt Lewin, social psychologist, 1940s, developed for organizational change management.

### TYPICAL USERS

Change managers, HR leaders planning organizational transitions.

### INPUTS → OUTPUTS

Input: a proposed change. Output: two ranked lists (driving and restraining forces) and a plan targeting the highest-impact ones.

### STRENGTHS

Simple, fast, and effective at surfacing hidden resistance before a change initiative launches.

### WEAKNESSES

Purely qualitative; doesn't capture force interactions or magnitude precisely.

### BEST USE CASES

Early planning for any organizational change with visible stakeholder resistance.

### FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS

Focusing only on driving forces (more advocacy) while ignoring restraining forces that will quietly kill the initiative.

### ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE

An ERP migration team mapping restraining forces (fear of job loss, legacy process attachment) and specifically designing training to address them.

### AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE

AI sentiment analysis of employee feedback channels can surface unspoken restraining forces the leadership team hasn't identified.

### PROMPT TEMPLATE

"List the forces pushing for this change and the forces resisting it. Which restraining force, if removed, would have the biggest effect?"

### RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS

Related: SWOT, Stakeholder Alignment. Contradicts nothing directly; complements Root Cause Analysis.

## SWOT

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A four-quadrant assessment of Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats, mapping internal factors against external ones.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Widely attributed to Albert Humphrey's work at Stanford Research Institute in the 1960s-70s, though the precise origin is disputed.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Nearly every level of business planning, from startups to board-level strategy reviews.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a business, product, or initiative. Output: a four-quadrant grid summarizing internal and external factors.

### **STRENGTHS**

Extremely accessible; forces at least a minimal separation of internal capability from external environment.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Notoriously prone to becoming a shallow listing exercise with no prioritization or resulting action.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Early-stage situational framing, especially with mixed-seniority groups needing a common starting vocabulary.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Producing a long, unprioritized list in each quadrant with no synthesis into an actual strategic choice.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A retailer's SWOT identifying store footprint as a strength and e-commerce capability as a weakness, driving a hybrid investment strategy.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can auto-populate a draft SWOT from market research, financial data, and competitor filings, giving the team a stronger starting point.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Generate a SWOT for this business, then rank each item by how much it should actually influence next year's strategy."

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: SOAR, PESTLE, Porter's Five Forces. Contradicts SOAR's deficit-framing emphasis.

**SOAR**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A strengths-based alternative to SWOT — Strengths, Opportunities, Aspirations, Results — that deliberately omits weaknesses and threats.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Developed in the early 2000s within the Appreciative Inquiry tradition of organizational development (Stavros, Cooperrider).

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Teams and organizations seeking a positive, generative strategy conversation rather than a deficit-focused one.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a business or team context. Output: a framing built around aspiration and desired measurable results.

### **STRENGTHS**

Generates energy and buy-in; useful when a team is demoralized by repeated deficit-focused analysis.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Can create blind spots by deliberately not examining weaknesses or threats — risky in genuinely high-risk situations.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Culture-change initiatives, vision-setting workshops, teams recovering from a difficult period.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Using SOAR in a situation with serious unaddressed risks, where the deliberate omission of threats becomes dangerous.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A post-turnaround leadership team using SOAR to rebuild morale and set an aspirational three-year vision after a rough restructuring.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI-facilitated workshops can generate aspiration statements grounded in real strength data rather than generic optimism.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Given our real strengths, what aspiration is genuinely achievable, and what measurable result would prove we got there?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: SWOT (deliberate contrast), Blue Ocean Strategy.

## **PESTLE**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A scan of macro-environmental factors — Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Legal, Environmental — that could affect a strategy.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Extension of Francis Aguilar's 1967 ETPS framework, later expanded to PESTLE/PESTEL.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Corporate strategists and market-entry teams assessing external, non-competitive risk factors.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a market or geography. Output: a structured list of macro-environmental factors and their likely strategic impact.

### **STRENGTHS**

Ensures macro risks (regulatory shifts, demographic change) aren't missed by teams focused only on competitive dynamics.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Broad and generic; without discipline it produces a long list with no prioritization of which factors actually matter.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Market entry analysis, long-range strategic planning, regulatory-sensitive industries.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Treating every PESTLE factor as equally important rather than identifying the two or three that are actually decision-relevant.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A energy company's PESTLE analysis flagging an upcoming carbon-tax regulation as the dominant factor reshaping five-year capital allocation.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI news and regulatory-filing monitoring can continuously update a PESTLE scan rather than treating it as a one-time exercise.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Scan Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Legal, and Environmental factors for this market — which two are most likely to materially change our strategy?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: SWOT, Horizon Scanning, Strategic Foresight.

## **Porter's Five Forces**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A model of industry structure analyzing competitive intensity via five forces: rivalry, supplier power, buyer power, threat of substitutes, and threat of new entrants.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Michael Porter, Harvard Business School, 'Competitive Strategy' (1979/1980).

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Corporate strategists assessing industry attractiveness before entering or investing further in a market.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: an industry. Output: a rating of each of the five forces and an overall assessment of structural profitability potential.

### **STRENGTHS**

Rigorous, widely understood shorthand for why some industries are structurally more profitable than others.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Static snapshot; underweights fast-moving digital ecosystems, platform dynamics, and complementors (addressed by later extensions).

### **BEST USE CASES**

Market entry decisions, industry attractiveness assessment before capital allocation.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Applying the framework once and treating the conclusion as permanent in a fast-evolving industry.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A new entrant assessing the cloud infrastructure market and correctly identifying extremely high buyer switching costs as the dominant force shaping strategy.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can continuously monitor supplier, buyer, and competitor data to keep a Five Forces assessment current rather than static.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Rate each of the five forces for this industry from 1 (weak) to 5 (strong), and identify which force most constrains profitability."

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: PESTLE, Blue Ocean Strategy (which explicitly seeks to escape Five Forces competition).

## **Scenario Planning**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Developing multiple plausible, internally consistent futures to stress-test a strategy against a range of outcomes rather than a single forecast.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Pioneered by Herman Kahn at RAND Corporation (1950s-60s), refined into corporate practice by Pierre Wack at Royal Dutch Shell (1970s).

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Corporate strategists, government planners facing deep structural uncertainty (energy, geopolitics, technology shifts).

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: key uncertainties facing the organization. Output: 3-4 distinct, internally consistent future scenarios and a strategy robust across them.

### **STRENGTHS**

Shell famously used it to anticipate the 1970s oil shocks while competitors were caught flat-footed by a single-point forecast.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Resource-intensive; scenarios can become an intellectual exercise disconnected from actual decision-making if not tied to concrete triggers.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Long-horizon strategy under deep uncertainty — energy transition, geopolitical exposure, technology disruption planning.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Building elaborate scenarios that never connect to a monitored trigger or an actual strategic decision.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

Shell's 1970s scenario planning, which included an oil-price-shock scenario that let the company respond faster than rivals when it occurred.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can generate a much wider set of candidate scenarios and stress-test a strategy against each computationally, beyond what a workshop can manually produce.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Generate three distinct, internally consistent future scenarios for this market over 5 years, and identify which of our current strategic bets survive in all three."

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: War Gaming, Strategic Foresight, Futures Thinking, Backcasting.

## **War Gaming**



### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Simulating a competitive interaction by having teams role-play the strategy's likely opponents (competitors, regulators) to stress-test it before real-world commitment.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Military tradition dating to Prussian Kriegsspiel (early 19th century); adapted for business strategy from the 1980s onward.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Corporate strategy teams preparing for competitive launches, M&A; negotiations, or regulatory battles.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a proposed strategic move. Output: a red team's simulated competitive response and a refined strategy accounting for it.

### **STRENGTHS**

Surfaces competitor reactions and blind spots that internal-only planning misses, since internal teams rarely think adversarially about their own plan.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Quality depends entirely on how realistically the 'opposing' team plays; a weak red team produces false confidence.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Major competitive launches, contested M&A;, regulatory or litigation strategy.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Staffing the red team with people unwilling to genuinely attack the plan, producing a rubber-stamp exercise.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A consumer goods company war-gaming a price cut by having an internal team play the leading competitor's likely retaliation, revealing the move would trigger a margin-destroying price war.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI agents can play a more relentless, less socially-inhibited adversary than internal staff, running many more iterations of competitive response.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Play the role of our strongest competitor. Given this move we're about to make, what is your most damaging response?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Red Teaming, Scenario Planning, OODA Loop.

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A structured discipline for exploring multiple plausible long-range futures (not predictions) to widen strategic imagination beyond the default trend extrapolation.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Rooted in futures studies as an academic field (Institute for the Future, established 1968); related to but broader than scenario planning.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Innovation strategists, government foresight units, R&D; portfolio planners.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a domain of interest. Output: a set of plausible, probable, and preferable futures mapped across a futures cone.

### **STRENGTHS**

Widens the strategic imagination beyond straight-line trend extrapolation, surfacing genuinely novel possibilities.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Can drift into speculative fiction disconnected from near-term decision relevance if not disciplined.

### **BEST USE CASES**

R&D; portfolio prioritization, long-range innovation strategy, technology roadmap planning.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Generating imaginative futures with no linkage back to a present-day resourcing or investment decision.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A telecom's futures-thinking exercise on 6G and ambient computing shaping which speculative R&D; bets get seed funding today.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI trend synthesis across patents, research papers, and startup funding can ground futures thinking in weak signals rather than pure speculation.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"What are three plausible (not just probable) futures for this domain in 10 years, and what would we need to start doing today to be ready for each?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Scenario Planning, Strategic Foresight, Horizon Scanning.

## **Strategic Foresight**

#### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

The organizational capability of systematically monitoring weak signals and emerging trends to anticipate strategic shifts before they become obvious.

#### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Developed in parallel with futures studies; institutionalized in corporate practice through dedicated foresight units (e.g. at Shell, Philips, Singapore's government).

#### **TYPICAL USERS**

Chief strategy officers, dedicated foresight teams, government policy planners.

#### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: continuous environmental scanning data. Output: an early warning of emerging strategic shifts and their implications.

#### **STRENGTHS**

Institutionalizes the practice of scenario planning and horizon scanning into an ongoing capability rather than a one-off workshop.

#### **WEAKNESSES**

Requires sustained organizational investment and executive attention; easily deprioritized when quarterly pressures dominate.

#### **BEST USE CASES**

Organizations in industries facing structural disruption risk (energy, media, financial services).

#### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Building a foresight function that produces reports nobody reads or acts on, disconnected from resource allocation decisions.

#### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

Singapore's government Centre for Strategic Futures continuously monitoring weak signals to inform national policy planning.

#### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI-powered continuous horizon scanning across news, patents, and research literature can operationalize foresight at a scale no human team could sustain manually.

#### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"What weak signals in adjacent industries or technologies could, if they strengthen, materially change our strategic position within 3 years?"

#### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Horizon Scanning, Futures Thinking, Scenario Planning.

## **Morphological Analysis**

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A method for systematically exploring all possible combinations of a problem's independent parameters to surface non-obvious solutions.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Fritz Zwicky, astrophysicist at Caltech, 1940s-60s, originally applied to aerospace engineering problems.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Product designers and engineers seeking to exhaustively map a solution space rather than anchor on the first idea.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a problem broken into independent parameter dimensions. Output: a matrix of all parameter combinations, screened for feasible and novel options.

**STRENGTHS**

Guards against premature anchoring on an obvious solution by forcing exploration of the full combinatorial space.

**WEAKNESSES**

Combinatorial explosion — the number of combinations grows fast, requiring disciplined screening criteria.

**BEST USE CASES**

Product design problems with several genuinely independent design parameters (e.g. form factor, power source, connectivity).

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Generating an enormous matrix and getting lost in it without a clear screening criterion to narrow down to viable options.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

Zwicky's original use to systematically enumerate possible jet and rocket propulsion configurations, some of which had not been previously considered.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can generate and screen far larger combinatorial matrices than manual workshops, surfacing viable but non-obvious combinations faster.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"List the independent parameters of this design problem, generate the full combination matrix, and flag the three most novel yet feasible combinations."

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: TRIZ, SCAMPER, Combinational Innovation.

## Assumption Mapping

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Explicitly cataloging and ranking the assumptions a strategy depends on, by how uncertain and how critical each one is to the strategy's success.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Common in lean startup and design thinking practice, formalized through tools like the Assumptions Grid (Ash Maurya, others).

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Product and strategy teams wanting to know which unproven beliefs their plan is most exposed to.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a strategy or business plan. Output: a 2x2 grid of assumptions by uncertainty and importance, prioritizing which to test first.

### **STRENGTHS**

Focuses limited validation effort (research, pilots) on the assumptions that would be most damaging if wrong.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Requires genuine intellectual honesty about which assumptions are shaky — teams often underrate their own key assumptions' uncertainty.

### **BEST USE CASES**

New product or market-entry planning before committing significant capital.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Testing easy, low-stakes assumptions first while leaving the truly load-bearing, high-uncertainty ones unexamined.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A fintech startup mapping 'customers will trust an app-only bank with savings' as their highest-uncertainty, highest-importance assumption, and testing it first via a small pilot.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can extract implicit assumptions embedded in a strategy document that the team hasn't consciously identified, expanding the assumption map's completeness.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"What assumptions does this strategy depend on? Rank each by how uncertain it is and how much the strategy would fail if it's wrong."

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Pre-mortem, Opportunity Mapping, Kill Criteria.

## **Opportunity Mapping**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Visually plotting potential opportunities by dimensions like market attractiveness and organizational fit, to prioritize where to invest.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

A practical evolution of portfolio-planning tools like the McKinsey/GE Matrix (1970s), applied to opportunity rather than existing business unit prioritization.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Innovation and product portfolio leaders deciding where to allocate scarce development resources.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a list of candidate opportunities. Output: a 2x2 or matrix plot ranking them by attractiveness and feasibility/fit.

### **STRENGTHS**

Forces explicit trade-off visibility across many competing opportunities rather than pursuing whichever is loudest internally.

### **WEAKNESSES**

The two chosen axes can oversimplify a genuinely multi-dimensional decision if picked carelessly.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Annual or quarterly portfolio planning across many candidate product or market opportunities.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Choosing axes that flatter a pre-decided favorite opportunity rather than genuinely informing the choice.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A healthcare company plotting new therapeutic areas by market size versus internal R&D; capability fit, deprioritizing a large but poorly-fitting market.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can score opportunities against attractiveness and fit criteria using market and internal capability data, reducing reliance on subjective internal advocacy.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Plot these opportunities by market attractiveness and our organizational fit — which quadrant deserves the next round of investment?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Opportunity Solution Trees, Jobs To Be Done, Blue Ocean Strategy.

## **Risk Heat Maps**

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A visual matrix plotting identified risks by likelihood and impact, to prioritize risk mitigation effort.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Standard tool in enterprise risk management (ISO 31000 and COSO ERM frameworks), widely adopted from the 1990s-2000s.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Risk officers, boards, project leaders needing a shared visual of where risk exposure concentrates.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a list of identified risks. Output: a color-coded matrix (likelihood x impact) prioritizing mitigation attention.

**STRENGTHS**

Extremely effective communication tool for boards and executives who need a fast, shared risk picture.

**WEAKNESSES**

Likelihood and impact scores are often subjective estimates dressed up as objective data; correlated risks are easy to miss on a simple 2D grid.

**BEST USE CASES**

Enterprise risk reviews, project risk registers, board risk reporting.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Treating the heat map as a complete risk analysis rather than a communication summary of a deeper underlying assessment.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A bank's operational risk heat map flagging cyber risk as high-likelihood, high-impact, directing disproportionate security investment there.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can continuously update likelihood estimates from real incident and threat-intelligence data rather than relying on annual subjective reassessment.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Score each of these risks by likelihood and impact, and flag which ones are correlated so we don't underestimate combined exposure."

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Error Management, Sensitivity Analysis, Pre-mortem.

## Decision Trees

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A branching diagram mapping sequential decisions and uncertain outcomes, with probabilities and payoffs, to calculate the expected value of each path.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Formal decision analysis developed by Ronald Howard and colleagues at Stanford in the 1960s, building on earlier statistical decision theory.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Investors, project managers, clinicians evaluating sequential decisions with quantifiable uncertainty.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a sequence of decisions and chance events with estimated probabilities and payoffs. Output: the expected value of each decision path, identifying the optimal one.

**STRENGTHS**

Makes sequential, compounding uncertainty explicit and calculable rather than intuited.

**WEAKNESSES**

Requires probability and payoff estimates that are often more subjective than the tree's precise appearance suggests.

**BEST USE CASES**

R&D; go/no-go staging decisions, clinical trial design, multi-stage capital investment decisions.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Presenting a decision tree's output with false precision when the underlying probability estimates are rough guesses.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A pharma company using a decision tree to value a drug candidate across sequential trial phases, each with a probability of success and cost.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can rapidly build and update decision trees as new probability information arrives, and run sensitivity analysis across many probability assumptions at once.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Map this as a decision tree with the sequential choices and chance events, estimate probabilities and payoffs, and compute the expected value of each path."

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Expected Value Thinking, Real Options, Monte Carlo Simulation.

## Influence Diagrams



### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A compact graphical alternative to decision trees, showing decisions, uncertainties, and their dependencies without the combinatorial explosion of a full tree.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Developed by Ronald Howard and Ross Shachter in decision analysis, 1980s, as a more scalable complement to decision trees.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Decision analysts modeling complex decisions with many interacting variables.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a set of decisions, uncertainties, and their dependency relationships. Output: a compact diagram showing which variables influence which decisions.

### **STRENGTHS**

Scales to far more variables than a decision tree without becoming visually unmanageable.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Less intuitive to non-specialists than a decision tree; usually requires a trained decision analyst to build and interpret correctly.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Complex decisions with many interdependent variables, such as large capital projects with multiple risk factors.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Building a diagram so complex that it obscures rather than clarifies the actual decision-relevant dependencies.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

An energy company modeling a power-plant investment decision with interdependent fuel price, regulatory, and demand uncertainty variables.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can help construct influence diagrams from unstructured planning documents by extracting the implied variable dependencies.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Model this decision's key uncertainties and their dependencies as an influence diagram rather than a full decision tree."

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Decision Trees, Sensitivity Analysis, Multi-Criteria Decision Analysis.

## **OODA Loop**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A four-stage cycle — Observe, Orient, Decide, Act — for making and adapting decisions faster than an opponent in a competitive, fast-changing situation.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Colonel John Boyd, U.S. Air Force fighter pilot and strategist, developed from air-combat analysis in the 1950s-70s.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Military commanders, crisis responders, competitive strategists in fast-moving markets.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a changing competitive situation. Output: a faster decision-action cycle than the opponent's, creating a tempo advantage.

### **STRENGTHS**

The 'Orient' stage explicitly foregrounds updating one's mental model, not just reacting faster — a key insight beyond simple speed.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Emphasizing speed can sacrifice decision quality if 'Orient' is rushed and mental models aren't genuinely updated.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Competitive situations where tempo itself is a source of advantage — fast-moving markets, live crisis response.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Treating OODA as 'decide fast' without the harder work of genuinely re-orienting when new information contradicts the existing plan.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A fast-fashion retailer's rapid observe-orient-decide-act cycle on trending styles, outpacing competitors' slower seasonal planning cycles.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can compress the Observe and Orient stages dramatically by synthesizing incoming signals in real time, leaving more human bandwidth for Decide and Act.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"What have we observed that should change our orientation — not just our next action, but our underlying model of the situation?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Mental Agility, Cynefin Framework, War Gaming.

## **Red Teaming**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Assigning a dedicated team to attack, critique, or attempt to defeat a plan from an adversarial perspective before it is finalized.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Military intelligence and wargaming tradition; formalized in U.S. Department of Defense doctrine and adopted broadly in cybersecurity and corporate strategy.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

National security agencies, cybersecurity teams, corporate strategy teams stress-testing major decisions.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a finalized or near-final plan. Output: a documented set of vulnerabilities, weaknesses, or attack vectors the red team identified.

### **STRENGTHS**

Institutionalizes adversarial scrutiny that a plan's own authors are structurally unable to provide for themselves.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Only as effective as the red team's independence and willingness to genuinely attack rather than soft-pedal criticism of leadership's plan.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Cybersecurity, major strategic decisions, M&A, high-stakes launches with limited room for error.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

A red team staffed by people who report to the plan's sponsor, producing polite, toothless critique.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

Cybersecurity red teams simulating real attacker behavior against a company's systems to find exploitable gaps before adversaries do.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI red-team agents can probe a plan or system relentlessly and at far greater scale than a human team, without social deference to the plan's authors.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Attack this plan as if you were our most capable adversary. Where does it break first?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Blue Teaming, Devil's Advocate, War Gaming, Pre-mortem.

## **Blue Teaming**

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

The defensive counterpart to red teaming — a team dedicated to defending, hardening, and improving a plan or system against identified attacks.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Paired with red teaming in military and cybersecurity exercise doctrine.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Cybersecurity teams, operational resilience planners responding to red-team findings.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: red-team findings. Output: a hardened plan or system addressing the identified vulnerabilities.

**STRENGTHS**

Converts adversarial critique into concrete resilience improvements, closing the loop that red teaming alone doesn't complete.

**WEAKNESSES**

Without a genuinely adversarial red team to respond to, blue teaming has nothing substantive to defend against.

**BEST USE CASES**

Immediately following any red-team exercise, and in ongoing security operations.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Treating blue-team hardening as a one-time patch rather than an ongoing response to continuously evolving threats.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A financial institution's blue team patching authentication gaps identified by an internal red-team penetration test.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can prioritize which red-team findings to remediate first based on modeled exploitability and business impact.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Given these red-team findings, which vulnerabilities should we fix first based on likely exploitability and impact?"

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Red Teaming, Error Management.

## Pre-Mortem

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Imagining a plan has already failed, then working backward to identify the causes, surfacing risks before they materialize.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Gary Klein, cognitive psychologist, popularized the technique in a 2007 Harvard Business Review article, building on 'prospective hindsight' research.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Project teams, investment committees, product launch teams before committing to a plan.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a plan not yet executed. Output: a list of plausible failure causes, identified while the plan can still be adjusted.

### **STRENGTHS**

Overcomes the social awkwardness of raising doubts about a plan mid-approval by reframing critique as a structured exercise everyone participates in.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Effectiveness depends on genuine psychological safety; a team that self-censors will produce a shallow pre-mortem.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Immediately before finalizing any consequential, hard-to-reverse plan.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Running the exercise as a formality, with the team already knowing leadership doesn't want to hear real risks.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A product team's pre-mortem surfacing that a planned launch date assumed a third-party API integration that had never actually been tested at scale.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can generate a broader, less socially-filtered list of plausible failure modes than a room of people worried about looking negative.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Imagine this plan failed completely a year from now. What are the five most likely reasons why?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Kill Criteria, Failure Mapping, Assumption Mapping, Devil's Advocate.

## **Post-Mortem**

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

A structured retrospective analysis after a project or decision concludes, examining what happened, why, and what should change going forward.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Adapted from medical autopsy terminology into engineering and project management practice, formalized in software (blameless post-mortems) and Agile practice.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Engineering teams, project managers, executives reviewing completed initiatives.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a completed project or decision and its outcome. Output: documented root causes and specific process changes for the future.

**STRENGTHS**

Converts individual experience into institutional learning; blameless post-mortems in particular improve psychological safety and honesty.

**WEAKNESSES**

Frequently skipped under time pressure, or conducted in a blame-oriented way that suppresses honest disclosure.

**BEST USE CASES**

After any significant project completion, incident, or decision with a measurable outcome — win or loss.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Conducting the post-mortem to assign blame rather than extract systemic lessons, which trains people to hide future problems.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

Google's blameless post-mortem culture for production incidents, explicitly separating root-cause analysis from individual performance evaluation.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can mine post-mortem documents across many projects to identify recurring root causes invisible at the level of any single review.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"What happened, what were the root causes, and what specific process change would prevent recurrence — without assigning individual blame?"

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Root Cause Analysis, Five Whys, Pre-mortem.

## Backcasting

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Starting from a defined desirable future state and working backward to identify the sequence of steps needed to get there, rather than forecasting forward from the present.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

John B. Robinson, environmental studies, 1980s-90s, originally applied to sustainable-energy futures planning.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Sustainability strategists, long-range planners setting ambitious, non-incremental goals.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a defined future goal state. Output: a working-backward sequence of milestones and required capabilities to reach it.

### **STRENGTHS**

Escapes the trap of incremental forward-forecasting, which tends to just extrapolate the present and underestimate necessary change.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Requires genuine commitment to the end-state goal; can produce an unrealistic plan if the goal itself wasn't feasibility-tested.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Ambitious multi-year transformation goals, sustainability and net-zero planning, moonshot initiatives.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Backcasting from a goal that was never realistically vetted, producing an elaborate plan toward an impossible destination.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A utility company backcasting from a 2040 net-zero target to identify which infrastructure investments must start this decade.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can help stress-test intermediate milestones in a backcasted plan against physical, financial, and regulatory feasibility constraints.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Assume we've achieved [target future state] by [date]. Working backward, what had to happen five years before, then three, then now?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Scenario Planning, Moonshot Thinking, Strategic Foresight.

## **Horizon Scanning**

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Systematically monitoring the external environment for early, weak signals of emerging trends, technologies, or risks.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Developed within futures studies and government foresight practice; formalized in the UK Government's Horizon Scanning Programme (2000s).

**TYPICAL USERS**

Corporate strategy and government foresight units maintaining continuous environmental awareness.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: continuous monitoring of external sources (research, patents, news, startup activity). Output: an early-warning list of emerging signals worth tracking.

**STRENGTHS**

Catches disruptive shifts earlier than competitors relying only on established industry reporting.

**WEAKNESSES**

Weak signals are, by definition, ambiguous — distinguishing genuine early trends from noise is genuinely hard.

**BEST USE CASES**

Ongoing strategic monitoring in fast-moving or disruption-prone industries.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Flooding decision-makers with too many unfiltered 'signals,' none of which get proper follow-through.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A pharmaceutical company's horizon scanning flagging early mRNA vaccine research years before it became a mainstream therapeutic category.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI text-mining across scientific literature, patents, and funding data can scan far more sources continuously than a small human foresight team.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Scan for weak signals in adjacent fields that, if they strengthen over the next 2-3 years, would materially affect our industry."

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Strategic Foresight, PESTLE, Futures Thinking.



## Part II — Counterfactual Thinking

*Tools for deliberately reasoning against the current plan — imagining it wrong, imagining it failed, imagining the opposite — to surface risks and alternatives that confirmation-seeking planning tends to miss.*

### Counterfactual Thinking

#### PURPOSE / CORE IDEA

Reasoning about alternative outcomes that did not happen ('what if X had been different') to understand causality and improve future decisions.

#### ORIGIN & CREATOR

Studied extensively in cognitive psychology (Kahneman & Tversky's work on counterfactual reasoning, 1980s).

#### TYPICAL USERS

Strategists and analysts examining past decisions to isolate what actually drove the outcome versus luck.

#### INPUTS → OUTPUTS

Input: a past decision and its outcome. Output: an alternative version of events and an assessment of how much the original choice actually mattered.

#### STRENGTHS

Separates decision quality from outcome luck, improving the accuracy of lessons drawn from history.

#### WEAKNESSES

Infinite counterfactuals are possible; without discipline, this becomes unfalsifiable storytelling.

#### BEST USE CASES

Post-mortems and case-study analysis where the goal is genuine causal understanding, not narrative comfort.

#### FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS

Constructing a counterfactual that flatters the original decision-maker rather than genuinely testing what mattered.

#### ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE

Analyzing whether a failed product launch was actually caused by timing (which could have been different) or by a flawed core value proposition (which couldn't).

#### AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE

AI can generate a wider, less self-serving range of counterfactual scenarios than the original decision-makers reviewing their own choice.

#### PROMPT TEMPLATE

"If [specific variable] had been different, would the outcome likely have changed? How much of this result was the decision versus circumstance?"

#### RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS

Related: What-if Analysis, Post-mortem, Alternative Histories.

### What-If Analysis

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Systematically varying key input assumptions to see how sensitive a plan's outcome is to each one.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

A staple of financial modeling and operations research; formalized as 'sensitivity analysis' in quantitative practice.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Financial analysts, operations planners stress-testing a model's key assumptions.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a model with key assumptions. Output: a table or chart showing how outcomes change as each assumption is varied.

**STRENGTHS**

Identifies which assumptions the plan is most fragile to, focusing risk-management attention appropriately.

**WEAKNESSES**

Typically varies one assumption at a time, missing compounding effects when multiple assumptions move together.

**BEST USE CASES**

Financial models, capacity plans, any forecast with several uncertain input variables.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Only testing 'friendly' what-if scenarios (small favorable variations) rather than genuinely stress-testing with adverse combinations.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A capital project's what-if analysis on commodity price, interest rate, and demand assumptions revealing the project only breaks even in a narrow band of conditions.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can run far more what-if combinations simultaneously (true multivariate sensitivity) than manual spreadsheet toggling allows.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Vary each key assumption in this plan independently and in combination — which ones, if wrong, break the plan?"

**RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Sensitivity Analysis, Monte Carlo Simulation, Counterfactual Thinking.

## Alternative Histories

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Constructing a plausible, detailed narrative of how history could have unfolded differently, to test the robustness of causal explanations for past events.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

A tradition in historiography (counterfactual history, e.g. Niall Ferguson's 'Virtual History') applied to business case analysis.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Strategy teams studying past industry-shaping events to extract genuinely transferable lessons.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a historical business event. Output: a plausible alternative narrative testing whether the actual outcome was inevitable or contingent.

### **STRENGTHS**

Prevents drawing overconfident lessons from history by testing whether the actual path was truly the only plausible one.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Highly speculative; without rigor, becomes entertaining but strategically useless storytelling.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Strategy education and case-study teaching, testing 'obvious in hindsight' industry narratives.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Presenting an alternative history as more knowable or certain than it actually is.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

Examining whether Blockbuster's decline was truly inevitable given streaming technology, or whether a plausible alternative history existed where earlier strategic pivots preserved the company.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can rapidly construct and evaluate multiple alternative historical narratives, drawing on broader historical pattern data than an individual analyst holds.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Construct a plausible alternative history where [key decision] went differently — how much would the ultimate outcome have actually changed?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Counterfactual Thinking, Historical Case Studies (Part on leaders).

## **Reverse Thinking**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Approaching a problem by considering its opposite or reverse framing — instead of 'how do we succeed,' asking 'how do we guarantee failure' or working backward from the end state.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

A generalized creativity and problem-solving technique with roots in inversion (see next entry) and lateral thinking.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Innovation teams and strategists stuck on a forward-framed problem.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a forward-framed problem. Output: the reversed framing, which often reveals the actual blocking constraint more clearly.

### **STRENGTHS**

Breaks mental fixation on a single framing direction; often surfaces the real constraint faster than the direct question.

### **WEAKNESSES**

A creativity technique, not a rigorous analytical method — useful for surfacing ideas, not for final validation.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Ideation sessions stuck in a rut, or diagnosing why a problem has resisted repeated forward-framed attempts.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Treating a reverse-thinking insight as a finished answer rather than a prompt for further validation.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A retention team reframing 'how do we increase retention' as 'how would we deliberately drive customers away,' surfacing overlooked friction points.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can rapidly generate the reversed framing of any stated problem as a standard first step in ideation, at negligible cost.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Instead of solving this directly, list everything that would guarantee failure — then check whether we're currently doing any of it."

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Inversion, Escape Thinking, SCAMPER.

## **Inversion**

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Solving a problem by explicitly identifying and avoiding what causes failure, rather than only pursuing what causes success.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Associated with Charlie Munger, who credited the mathematician Carl Jacobi's maxim 'invert, always invert.'

**TYPICAL USERS**

Investors, risk managers, and strategists who want to systematically avoid known failure patterns.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a goal. Output: a list of behaviors or conditions that would guarantee failure, used as a negative checklist.

**STRENGTHS**

Failure modes are often easier to enumerate reliably than success paths, making inversion a highly practical risk-reduction tool.

**WEAKNESSES**

Avoiding all failure modes doesn't guarantee success — it's a necessary but not sufficient discipline.

**BEST USE CASES**

Investment due diligence, risk-averse decision contexts, avoiding known catastrophic mistakes.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Treating a clean 'avoid failure' checklist as equivalent to having a positive strategy for success.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

Munger's investing discipline of identifying what destroys a business (excess leverage, capital misallocation) and rigorously avoiding those, rather than only seeking upside.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can compile a comprehensive checklist of known failure patterns across many historical cases faster than an individual's personal experience allows.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Instead of asking how to succeed, list everything that reliably destroys value in this type of situation — are we doing any of it?"

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Reverse Thinking, Kill Criteria, Pre-mortem.

## Devil's Advocate

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Assigning a person or team to deliberately argue against the prevailing view, to surface weaknesses that consensus-seeking discussion suppresses.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Historically the 'Advocatus Diaboli' role in Catholic Church canonization proceedings; adapted into general decision-making practice.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Boards, investment committees, any group vulnerable to groupthink on a consequential decision.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a decision with emerging consensus. Output: a formally argued opposing case, regardless of whether the advocate personally believes it.

**STRENGTHS**

Institutionalizes dissent so no individual bears the full social cost of raising doubts about a popular plan.

**WEAKNESSES**

Can become ritualistic and easily dismissed ('that's just the assigned dissenter') if not taken seriously by the group.

**BEST USE CASES**

Board decisions, investment committee approvals, any high-consensus, high-stakes decision.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Rotating the devil's advocate role so casually that no one takes the exercise seriously, or dismissing its findings by default.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

An investment committee formally assigning a devil's advocate to argue against a deal that the rest of the committee is enthusiastic about, before final approval.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can be prompted to argue the opposing case with full rigor and no social hesitance, serving as a consistent, always-available devil's advocate.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Argue as forcefully as possible against the decision the group currently favors. Do not hold back to be polite."

**RELATED / CONTRADICTORY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Red Teaming, Cognitive Bravery, Intellectual Humility.

## Kill Criteria

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Pre-defined, objective conditions established in advance that will trigger stopping or abandoning a plan, set before emotional or sunk-cost investment builds up.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Military and project-management practice; formalized in stage-gate innovation processes and venture investing.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Product teams, investors, project sponsors managing initiatives with real abandonment risk.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a new initiative. Output: specific, measurable conditions that, if met, mandate stopping the initiative regardless of sunk investment.

### **STRENGTHS**

Counters sunk-cost bias and escalation of commitment by locking in the decision criteria before emotional attachment forms.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Kill criteria set too loosely provide false discipline; set too rigidly, they can force abandonment of a plan that just needs more time.

### **BEST USE CASES**

R&D; stage-gates, venture-backed pilot programs, any initiative prone to sunk-cost-driven over-persistence.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Quietly revising kill criteria upward once the original threshold is about to be triggered, defeating their purpose.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A pharma R&D; pipeline with pre-defined kill criteria at each trial phase, preventing continued investment in drugs showing weak efficacy signals.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI monitoring can track kill-criteria metrics continuously and flag triggers objectively, removing the temptation to informally waive them.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Before we start, what specific, measurable result would mean we should stop this initiative — and who is accountable for enforcing that if it happens?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Pre-mortem, Inversion, Real Options.

## **Failure Mapping**

**PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Systematically cataloging the ways a system or plan could fail, and their likely causes, before failure occurs.

**ORIGIN & CREATOR**

Related to Failure Mode and Effects Analysis (FMEA), developed in aerospace and defense engineering in the 1950s-60s.

**TYPICAL USERS**

Engineering teams, operations leaders designing resilient systems and processes.

**INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a system or process. Output: a catalog of potential failure modes, their likely causes, and their severity.

**STRENGTHS**

Systematic and comprehensive — less likely to miss a failure mode than an unstructured brainstorm.

**WEAKNESSES**

Time-intensive for complex systems; can produce an overwhelming catalog without clear prioritization.

**BEST USE CASES**

Safety-critical systems, new product launches, any process where failure has significant downstream cost.

**FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Producing an exhaustive failure catalog but never prioritizing or acting on the highest-severity items.

**ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

An automotive manufacturer's FMEA process systematically identifying and prioritizing potential failure points in a new vehicle system before production.

**AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can cross-reference a proposed system design against databases of known failure patterns in similar systems, surfacing failure modes a team might not think of.

**PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Catalog every plausible way this system could fail, rank by severity and likelihood, and identify which ones lack a current mitigation."

**RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Pre-mortem, Risk Heat Maps, Root Cause Analysis.

## Escape Thinking



### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Deliberately imagining ways to break free of the current constraints, rules, or business model entirely — asking what would be possible with no existing limitations.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

A creativity-technique variant related to lateral thinking (de Bono) and 'blank slate' design ideation.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Innovation teams facing an incumbent's structural constraints (legacy systems, existing customer base, regulatory habits).

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: a constrained current business or process. Output: an unconstrained ideal version, then a gap analysis of what's actually achievable.

### **STRENGTHS**

Prevents incremental thinking from anchoring too heavily on the status quo's assumed constraints.

### **WEAKNESSES**

Ideas generated this way often aren't feasible as-is and require a disciplined second pass to ground them in reality.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Early-stage innovation ideation, especially for incumbents at risk of being disrupted by unconstrained new entrants.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Generating unconstrained ideas but never doing the follow-up work to identify which constraints are actually removable.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A legacy bank imagining what it would build with no branch network or legacy core-banking system, then identifying which of those constraints could realistically be relaxed.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can generate genuinely unconstrained concepts unburdened by an organization's internalized assumptions about what's 'realistic.'

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"If none of our current constraints (legacy systems, org structure, existing customers) existed, how would we solve this? Then: which constraints are actually removable?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Moonshot Thinking, First Principles Thinking, Blue Ocean Strategy.

## **Anti-Goals**

### **PURPOSE / CORE IDEA**

Explicitly defining outcomes the organization wants to avoid, to bound strategy and decision-making alongside its positive goals.

### **ORIGIN & CREATOR**

An extension of inversion logic into goal-setting practice, used informally in strategic planning and OKR-adjacent methodologies.

### **TYPICAL USERS**

Strategy and leadership teams setting organizational direction alongside standard positive goals.

### **INPUTS → OUTPUTS**

Input: an organization's positive goals. Output: an explicit list of outcomes to actively avoid, used to bound strategic choices.

### **STRENGTHS**

Prevents a positive goal (e.g. 'grow revenue') from being pursued in ways that violate other unstated but important values (e.g. customer trust).

### **WEAKNESSES**

Anti-goals are easy to state and easy to quietly ignore under growth pressure unless tied to real accountability.

### **BEST USE CASES**

Strategic planning cycles, especially for organizations with a history of goal-driven overreach.

### **FAILURE MODES / ANTI-PATTERNS**

Listing anti-goals as a symbolic exercise with no actual decision-review mechanism to enforce them.

### **ENTERPRISE EXAMPLE**

A social media company setting an anti-goal of 'do not optimize engagement in ways that measurably harm user wellbeing,' used as an explicit check on feature design decisions.

### **AI IMPLEMENTATION ANGLE**

AI can flag when a proposed initiative's likely side effects conflict with a stated anti-goal, before launch rather than after.

### **PROMPT TEMPLATE**

"Alongside our positive goals for this strategy, what outcomes are we explicitly committing to avoid — and how would we know if we were drifting toward one?"

### **RELATED / CONTRADICTIONARY FRAMEWORKS**

Related: Inversion, Kill Criteria, Anti-pattern Catalog.